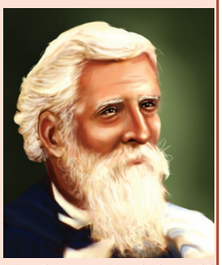
Dravidian and Non-Brahmin Identity

In 1801 Madras Presidency was formed by the colonial regime as a multilingual province (Tamils, Telegus, Malayalees, Kannadigas and Tulus). India's diversity could be noticed in the political developments of the Madras Presidency. In Bengal and in the rest of North India a Sanskrit and Vedic centered Indian culture was projected, besides an Indo-Aryan or Indo-German group of languages were acknowledged. Non-Vedic, Non-Sanskrit cultures were not recognized. The deciphering of Brahmi script in 1837 by James Principe and researches on south Indian languages (***Ellis in 1816 and Caldwell in 1856***) came to establish that Indian culture was not homogeneous; and there existed a (Non-Aryans) group of languages and countries.



Francis Whyte Ellis

Francis Whyte Ellis (1777-1819) was an eminent civil servant of East India Company's government at Madras. In 1810 he became the collector of Madras. In 1812 he established the College of Fort St.George to train company's servants in the south Indian languages.Ellis himself became a scholar in Sanskrit and Tamil. He adored Thirukural and translated eighteen chapters of Arathupal into English. In his foreword to Alexander Duncan Campbell's "Telugu Grammar" Ellis had brilliantly elaborated the **"Dravidian Proof"** of the South Indian languages. Thus Ellis was the first to declare that the South Indian languages led by Tamil belonged to a non-Sanskrit non-Aryan Dravidian family of languages. Iyothi Dasar hailed Ellis as the forerunner of the Tamil Renaissance.



Robert Caldwell

Robert Caldwell (1814-1891) As a Christian missionary he came to Madras Presidency in 1838 and settled at Idaiyankudi in Tirunelveli region. He was an eminent linguist and philologist. His monumental research work **"A Comparative Grammar of the Dravidian or South Indian Family of Languages"** (1856) established that the South Indian languages, Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Malayalam and Tulu, were basically distinct from the Aryan or Sanskrit group of languages, and these South Indian languages led by Tamil, ought to be classified as **"Dravidian family of languages."** He attributes more ancient antiquity to Tamil. He pointed out that there were Tamil or Dravidian words in the ancient Christian scriptures. The Dravidian theory of South Indian languages ,pronounced first by F.W.Ellis in 1816, was consolidated through Caldwell's "Comparative Grammar" in 1856. He also authored a book on "History of Tirunelveli", His wife Eliza Mault rendered yeoman service in educating the girls of the marginalized sections of society. Caldwell's researches established the uniqueness and antiquity of the Dravidian languages led by Tamil.

Buddhist and Dravidian traditions also existed in India. In the south, especially in the multi-lingual Madras Presidency, theories on Dravidian group of languages and Dravidian cultural heritage led to assertion of Dravidian identity among the Non-Brahmin.

Two factors (1) Brahmins claiming superiority over Non-Brahmins and (2) Brahmins monopolizing educational

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